

Perfection, Buh Buh Tall One, and Prayer for the Dead.

A letter from Priest Seraphim. 6th Sunday after Pentecost.

July 11/24, 2022

http://www.orthodox.net/letters/letter_2022-07-24+6th-sun-after-pentecost+perfection+prayer-for-the-dead.docx

http://www.orthodox.net/letters/letter_2022-07-24+6th-sun-after-pentecost+perfection+prayer-for-the-dead.pdf

Yes, pursue perfection, but also remember that (some) “perfection is the enemy of the good”.

I try to get a letter out by Friday, and date it for the following Sunday, but I usually fail. Therefore, this letter is coming out on the Wednesday *after* Sunday (well, er... actually the Tuesday after the Wednesday I said the letter was coming! The squirrel wheel has been going very fast lately). Because of the late date, I’m throwing in the towel for trying to get something out for the 5th Sunday after Pentecost. So, I am skipping a week. Perhaps my reasons (not excuses) will be helpful to someone.

I am learning, much too slowly, the absolute truth of the aphorism “**perfection is the enemy of the good.**”

Trying to be perfect is a fool’s errand, except in one case! We are called to perfection, and even ordered to become perfect (“Be ye therefore perfect, even as your Father which is in heaven is perfect.” (Mat 5:48)) and the Lord means this, *literally*! The beautiful irony of our calling is that every step to perfection that we make is *imperfect*. As our ordination prayer for the priesthood goes; God “fills the infirm vessel.” God makes our feeble steps stronger and corrects our mistakes. But **He will not correct mistakes we do not make!**

We must do what we can, and if this is very close to *all* we can do (we can do easy things, but nobody ever got strong by lifting *easy* weights), then God makes us stronger so that we can do more. The reason why so many of us are weak, including yours truly, is because we don’t reach the limits of

our ability very often, we don’t do what we can in a spiritual sense. We lift “light weights” spiritually, we don’t get much stronger.

I try to do what I can, and sometimes I even reach my limits. But sometimes my limits are sometimes self-imposed, such as trying to get the perfect letter out. I want to write original material for you because everybody can find quotes from the fathers online. I’m more interested in a personal connection for people to see that I am doing (trying to do) the stuff that I talk about, and that I make mistakes. It’s great to read the lives of the saints, but sometimes they seem inaccessible to us because the author of the life didn’t include any mistakes. There were plenty!

I had already written an article for the letter and it was ready a week ago, however, because of the commemoration of St Paisios of Mount Athos, last week, I wanted to include something about him. He is one of my favorites, and reading his biography changed the way I pray and approach ministry more than anything else I have ever experienced. There is a document that he wrote called the “Beatitudes”, and it’s wonderful. But the letter would be mostly quoting his beautiful work. And I suppose I will do that someday, because there will be a week where I just can’t get a letter done. I had two candidates for the letter, and both of them were pretty much ready to go but I had paralysis by analysis. And now here I am writing something a little different because when I write letters basically my heart just takes over.

I've talked before about the most important things to do each day. I try to follow that advice. The most critical thing for us to do each day is to pray. Our prayer has to be much more than just a few words we mumble in the morning or a couple of things at night. We benefit from formal prayer, with prostrations and intense commemorations of those that are significant in our life. We benefit from reading the Psalter, reading the lives of the saints, and reading the Gospels. All this takes time.

In my early priesthood, sometimes I was busy *doing things* and didn't understand that the thing that needed *doing* the most was personal prayer. That is number one on the to-do list, every day - my major work (your major work) every day, is prayer. Now unfortunately by that definition sometimes I don't work a full day! But I do what I can, and I get better.

May Buh Buh Tall One find paradise!

Unfortunately, last week on Wednesday, July 20, we received the news that my daughter-in-law Elizabeth's father, Trey, also known as "Buh Buh tall one" by his grandson Owen Daniel, had a tire blowout while traveling at high speed and this precipitated an accident involving only his truck, in which he died.

I know a little something about the sudden death of loved ones. It's pretty difficult really. I get through it with prayer.

The reason why I call him "Buh Buh Tall One" is because that is how Owen referred to him when he bragged about him, constantly! He is 6 foot seven, and the love between those two is very much mutual. I've never seen a shred of violence in the man, however, since is tall, his grandson is very proud of

Emphasizing prayer and reading holy things means that there are other things that don't get done. And we have a very full-service schedule, and I take care of my 3 grand boys at least twice a week. And I will never give that up for anything. So, there's only so much time, and when you add in the latent laziness in my bones, sometimes things don't get done.

So, there you have it! These are reasons why the letters are late but they are not excuses! I have no excuse for anything. I either do things, or I don't. Sometimes I do the things that I value and other times I allow other things that I don't value much in my heart to overcome me and take time away from the things that matter. I think that after prayer, and my boys, and the services, and travel to Marshall for prison ministry, this letter matters.

him and says he can "whip people up". I am known as "Buh Buh Beard One", because of course I have a beard, and I'm glad he doesn't call me "Buh Buh Short One". When Owen Daniel was very small, he called me "Buh", and since then he certainly knows that my other grandchildren call me Papa, but he stayed with Buh, and then added another "Buh."

We had the joy of taking care of Owen a couple of days and nights after the news, but it was a little bittersweet because I knew that eventually, he was going to be told, and he often mentioned his Buh Buh Tall One (or, sometimes, he refers to him as "Tall One Buh.") He's only four years old. It is hard to understand things at four years old. In my experience, it's sometimes also hard to understand things at 64 years old.

Prayer for non-Orthodox reposed.

Orthodox Christians pray for the dead. The reasons are really extremely simple. The primary reason is the same as the primary reason for everything that we do: love. Love does not end when a person's terrestrial life ends. What an idea! We still love them!

And although their body is dead, their soul is alive. Since man was made in the image of God in order to obtain His likeness, he was made to be an eternal being, and God never reneges on His word.

Therefore, everyone who was born will never "wink" out of existence. The death that is referred to in Genesis, where God says that if Adam (or Eve, since Adam certainly told her about this command) eat the fruit of a certain tree they will surely die means spiritual death and not the cessation of existence.

("And the LORD God commanded the man, saying, Of every tree of the garden thou mayest freely eat: (17) But of the tree of the knowledge of good and evil, thou shalt not eat of it: for in the day that thou eatest thereof thou shalt surely die." Gen 2:16-17)

The soul will always be alive, and at the second coming, the body will become alive also, whether a person is among the blessed or the wretched.

We also pray for the dead because of humility. We don't know everything about everything. It is even more accurate to say that we don't know much about much. God has not revealed to us everything about the next life.

We also pray for the dead because of obedience. The church has always prayed for the dead, so who are we to take on some sort of Protestant state of mind and not pray for the dead?

One of the adjustments that is difficult for many people to make regarding Orthodox piety is that we pray for the dead, and they interpret this as a statement that we think that the person who died did not go to heaven. It's even taken as a lack of faith or apostasy to pray for the dead. The church never

believed that. We love those who have reposed, and God has not revealed everything to us, and therefore we pray for everyone, whether they are alive or dead. We know that our Lord created the universe, and time is merely a construct of the fallen world. He knows all things, and to Him, a thousand years are as a day and a day are as a thousand years. Therefore, we pray.

We who are Orthodox don't try to define things that we don't understand. God has revealed to us many things, and we vigorously defend these things , however, the things that He has not revealed unto us we don't look into too much. He has not fully revealed to us the state of the soul after death, and so we don't look into it too much.

God has revealed to us what membership in the church is. It is to be a baptized Orthodox Christian. This is a "quantitative" assessment. It is not a judgment of the worth of a person. "Buh Buh Tall one" is much taller than I am and I have a beard and he was clean-shaven; this does not indicate anything about our personalities or our personal worth or how God will judge us.

We make a quantitative assessment regarding whether a person is in the church are not. This is not a qualitative assessment. We do not judge if a person is saved or damned. God knows all things and God will do all things according to His will. We don't make any judgments about those who have died outside of the church. May God save them all! Many of us, including myself, believe that God will save many that were not officially in the church, and certainly, the Gospel about the wheat and the tares tells us that many who rested in confidence as members of the Orthodox Church will go to Hell because they didn't live as Christians.

We do have a tradition regarding those who have died not being baptized members of the Orthodox

Church. Archbishop Peter has taught us that one of the reasons why we don't do prayer services in the church for those who are not Orthodox Christians is because we are respecting their free will. They were not Orthodox Christians in this life, and we're not going to convert them when they have nothing to say about it.

But we are going to pray for them. And it is a tradition to pray the prayer of St. Varus for those who have died, not being Orthodox Christians. And we pray the prayer humbly, without prejudice, and without judgment. Judgment can be in both directions, you know. We can say that any person we love is "saved" and not pray for them, ever, or we can say a person is not saved and never pray for them because we, in our arrogance, think that we somehow know the mind of God! This would be a terrible sin! What we should do is say: "I love him, and I will pray for him!"

There is another important tradition regarding our prayer for the dead. We believe that in some way God responds to our prayer for the dead but we don't know how. And we don't really care! After all, we pray because of love, and those who do things because of love do them only because of love, and not because of expectations.

We believe that when we pray for someone who is among the blessed, they hear our prayers and pray for us. And perhaps if they are not among the blessed God will save them. So it is, certainly not "exactly" as our Holy Fathers have said, but according to the spirit of the teaching of the church, a "win win." We pray for the dead until God shows unmistakably that they are among the blessed. And until that time, we quietly believe whatever we wish, but we pray.

Therefore, I have added Trey's name to "Daniels list". It is a list of those who have died suddenly since my son +Daniel died suddenly a little over five years

ago. I pray for those who are Orthodox and those who are not who died suddenly.

We pray to St. Varus because of a tradition regarding his life. He died a martyr, and a pious widow, named Veronica, took his relics from the holy land to her country. And she asked him to pray to the Lord for her deceased pagan relatives. After a little while, St. Varus appeared to her and told her that his prayer for her relatives have been answered and they were saved.

I also think it's appropriate to pray the prayer that priests say in the requiem services, "O God of spirits...", because the prayer makes no assumption that a person is Orthodox or not. Some people would consider my advice to be controversial because this prayer is normally prayed by a priest in the service, and that is true, however, I'm Irish and stubborn, and see no reason why a person cannot pray this beautiful prayer *in their home* for their loved ones.

We can also pray for our loved ones by merely saying "Lord Jesus Christ, have mercy upon (N.)" It is very simple to pray for the dead, as long as we remember that their souls are not dead.

Another simple reason why we pray for the dead is that even though we loved them in this life, human nature is to begin to forget things, even people that are important to us. If we pray for our loved ones every day, we are remembering them every day. Now a person might say "I will never forget so-and-so", but then after a little while there might be days that pass when they don't think of them. Forgetfulness is a funny thing! When we are forgetting, we don't know that we are forgetting! Praying for them every day ensures that we always think of them. There is something very precious and holy about keeping the memory of our loved ones constant in our minds.

You may see the prayer of St. Varus, the prayer "O God of spirits..." and the life of St. varus in "+Daniels list". If you look carefully, you will be able to find

Trey's name in there. It is available here:

<http://www.orthodox.net/daniel/dyptichs-daniels-list.doc> &
<http://www.orthodox.net/daniel/dyptichs-daniels-list.pdf>.

May God save all of our loved ones, the living and the reposed, and comfort us when we have losses.

In Christ, unworthy Priest Seraphim.

Recent stuff:

[St Paisios of Mt Athos. Some stories that illustrate that he is the “mother and brother” of Christ, whose easy yoke and light burden he took on.](#)

Audio: http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/saints-07-01_paisios-of-athos+mother-and-brother-of-christ.mp3

Video: <https://youtu.be/77BNLqYD1Vw>

Partial Timestamps

0:39 Artillery spotter.

1:26 – 2:29 Visions of St Euphemia and a soul with philotimo – even regarding the location of an outhouse!

3:11 – 3:31 When traveling, he tried to keep his evening rule a secret.

3:41 - 4:33 A Description of St Paisios: "Who is My mother and who are My brothers?" 49 And He stretched out His hand toward His disciples and said, "Here are My mother and My brothers! 50 For whoever does the will of My Father in heaven is My brother and sister and mother. cf. Matthew 12:46-13:3

4:46 – 11:35 Why is there blasphemy and moral confusion in our age, even among some of our hierarchs? Because they do not fully understand this: “All things are delivered unto me of my Father: and no man knoweth the Son, but the Father; neither knoweth any man the Father, save the Son, and he to whomsoever the Son will reveal him.” (Mat 11:27) **A commentary on the public and promoted baptism of 2 surrogate children of a very public and secular gay “couple”.**

11:35 - 13:41 St Paisios prays for a man he does not know, and saves him from suicide.

14:24 – 17:23 The core of St Paisios’ success: He obeyed this directive: “Take my yoke upon you, and learn of me; for I am meek and lowly in heart: and ye shall find rest unto your souls. (30) For my yoke is easy, and my burden is light.” Mat 11:29-30 **A discussion of the burden of the yoke of Christ vs the burden of sin.**

[Signs and entitlement. Keeping the house clean. Matthew 12:12-38-45](#)

Video: <https://youtu.be/dxn7gZ8WPYA>

Audio: http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/pen-wed-05_2022+signs-and-entitlement+keeping-the-house-clean_mat12-38-45.mp3

Commentary on MATTHEW 12:38-45, especially our modern “entitlement” and seeking of signs. We do not need to look to politics and media for entitlement; we need only look at the mirror. We look at how “entitlement” is, at its core, an expression of our pride. We also apply our Lord’s words about a man being delivered from a demon, who does nothing, and the demon comes back with 7 spirits that are even more evil. This story applies to us, if we have ears to hear. We discuss how to ensure that when the “demon returns”, he will find a house that is “swept and in good order”, but is not empty.

Incomplete Timestamps

10:37 – 12:06 More about the baptism of children adopted (or bought through surrogacy) of actively, openly homosexual couples.

[We gird up our loins as sojourners through the temptations of this world, and abstain from fleshly lusts, striving according to the example of Jesus Christ, with a lively hope, unto an inheritance incorruptible, Holy Apostles Peter and Paul](#)

Audio: http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/saints-06-29_2022+apostles-peter-and-paul.mp3

YouTube: <https://youtu.be/EBgrKEGV76I>

Exegesis of several verses from the 1 Peter, which we read during Vespers for the feast of the Apostles Peter and Paul. We include a critique of the lamentable recent baptism of two children by an openly gay couple, by Archbishop Elpidophoros, since it blatantly contradicts one of the verses we examine. **1 Peter 1:3,4,6-9,11,13,17,2:20-21**

Partial Audio Timestamps

1:23 – 4:21 “Blessed be the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ, which according to his abundant mercy hath begotten us again unto a lively hope by the resurrection of Jesus Christ from the dead. **(1 Peter 1:3)**

1:41 – 2:57 Three types of knowledge we need in the Christian life.

4:05 – 6:51 “To an inheritance incorruptible, and undefiled, and that fadeth not away, reserved in heaven for you” **(1 Peter 1:4)**

6:51 – 8:00 Why Could the martyrs endure? “Wherein ye greatly rejoice, though now for a season, if need be, ye are in heaviness through manifold temptations: 7 That the trial of your faith, being much more precious than of gold that perisheth, though it be tried with fire, might be found unto praise and honour and glory at the appearing of Jesus Christ: 8 Whom having not seen, ye love; in whom, though now ye see him not, yet believing, ye rejoice with joy unspeakable and full of glory: 9 Receiving the end of your faith, even the salvation of your souls” **(1 Peter 1:6-9)**

8:00 – 11:05 What am I trying to do to get you ready?

11:09 – 12:20 “Wherefore gird up the loins of your mind, be sober, and hope to the end for the grace that is to be brought unto you at the revelation of Jesus Christ;” **(1 Peter 1:13)**

12:20 – 14:22 “And if ye call on the Father, who without respect of persons judgeth according to every man's work, pass the time of your sojourning here in fear...” **(1 Peter 1:17)**

14:22 – 19:32 “Dearly beloved, I beseech you as strangers and pilgrims, abstain from fleshly lusts, which war against the soul;” **(1 Peter 2:11)** With application to the well-publicized (and praised!) baptism and “photo-op” that Archbishop Elpidophoros participated in, when two adopted children of two *openly* gay men who are “partners” were baptized by him, in Greece (07-09-2022)

19:32 – 21:28 “For what glory is it, if, when ye be buffeted for your faults, ye shall take it patiently? but if, when ye do well, and suffer for it, ye take it patiently, this is acceptable with God. 21 For even hereunto were ye called: because Christ also suffered for us, leaving us an example, that ye should follow his steps:” **(1 Peter 2:20-21)**

[Commentary: Recent baptism of children of an openly gay couple by Archbishop Elpidophoros](#)

YouTube: <https://youtu.be/xeAv3A7iMuw>

Audio: http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/misc_2022+ab-elpidophoros-baptism-of-children-of-openly-gay-couple_1pet-2-20-21.mp3

Commentary on the well-publicized (and praised!) baptism and “photo-op” that Archbishop Elpidophoros participated in, when adopted children of two openly gay men who are partners were baptized by him, in Greece (07-09-2022), as part of an exegesis of **1 Peter 2:11**, ““Dearly beloved, I beseech you as strangers and pilgrims, abstain from fleshly lusts, which war against the soul;” From a longer sermon, at http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/saints-06-29_2022+apostles-peter-and-paul.mp3

The text accompanying the photo, from a Facebook post, is as follows: " Last night was one of the best nights of our lives!! We are proud to have christened our children Alexios and Eleni in the first openly gay baptism in the Greek Orthodox church! The Archbishop of America, his Eminence Elpidophoros for pushing change and love with no judgement of anyone in the church and honoring us by christening our angels. We want to thank our families and friends who joined and our 8 godparents! We love you!!! Special thank you to Papou and Yiayia for throwing the best party ever!! @toniaandronikou thank you for putting up with us for 6 months and pulling through and making our dream night come true!!! And my baby @peter_dundas for making this fantasy night for all the parents and kids that came! @annaroussos @thanosasfis #AlexiosAndEleni"

[Authority, freedom, treasure.](#)

http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/pen-sun-04_2022+authority-freedom-treasure.mp3

The story of the healing of the centurion’s servant shows us a man whom Jesus praised as having the greatest faith in all of Israel. He was a man who understood authority. This is because he had personal freedom. Freedom is only possible when the heart is free from sin, and this process only occurs when our treasure is God. We weave together all four readings of the day, all of which speak about authority, freedom and treasure. Matthew 8:5-13, Luke 12:32-40, Romans 6:18-23, Galatians 5:22-6:2

Partial Audio timestamps

1:58 - 3:24 The right view of authority.

3:24 – 4:50 Spiritual meaning of “And God blessed them, and God said unto them, Be fruitful, and multiply, and replenish the earth, and subdue it: and have dominion over the fish of the sea, and over the fowl of the air, and over every living thing that moveth upon the earth.” Gen 1:28

4:50 – 9:00 the only way to have authority is to be free from sin.

7:10 – 9:00 the Christian meaning of the word “compel” – “And the lord said unto the servant, Go out into the highways and hedges, and compel them to come in, that my house may be filled.” (Luke 14:23)

11:46 – 16:19 A Description of Lucifer’s fall.

[“Not under the law, but under grace.” The *energy* to do good.](#)

YouTube: <https://youtu.be/6og9xwEfA2g>

Homily during liturgy at our “Marshall house”, a house used for housing for parolees from Texas prisons. We mostly comment on St Pauls’ epistle to the Romans, which gives use the *reason* and the *energy* to do good things, and avoid sin. It is not about rules, in is about grace, and gratitude: “For sin shall not have dominion over you: for ye are not under the law, but under grace.” “But God be thanked, that ye were the servants of sin, but ye have obeyed from the heart that form of doctrine which was delivered you.” And from the Gospel, “(He) ... Himself took our infirmities, and bare our sicknesses.” 4th Sat after Pentecost Romans 6:11-17

[The New Martyrs of the Turkish Yoke teach us how to use our freedom, against the day when we are not free.](#)

http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/pen-sun-03_2022+nm-turkish-yoke+freedom.mp3

Many times, a person loses something and after its loss, they realize they didn’t realize lies what they had until it was lost. So it is with the freedoms we have now history shows in our current situation implies that there will be a day when we have less freedom. Are we living in a way that is truly free today? We use the readings of today to discuss the New Martyrs of the Turkish yoke and particularly the life of the holy martyr Timothy of Esphigmenou, how we should be living now to be ready for tomorrow.

Audio timestamps:

1:48 - 4:51 How to get ready for persecution and difficulties, now while we have freedom.

5:16 – 13:42 Life of Martyr Timothy of Esphigmenou

12:27 - 13:42 Why should we read the lives of the martyrs, particularly those who apostatized, then repented?

13:57 – 16:37 “And we know that all things work together for good to them that love God, to them who are the called according to his purpose.” Rom 8:28

16:37 – 17:47 “For whom he did foreknow, he also did predestinate to be conformed to the image of his Son, that he might be the firstborn among many brethren.” Rom 8:29

17:47 – 21:34 “What shall we then say to these things? If God be for us, who can be against us?” Rom 8:31 And “For I am persuaded, that neither death, nor life, nor angels, nor principalities, nor powers, nor things present, nor things to come, {39} Nor height, nor depth, nor any other creature, shall be able to separate us from the love of God, which is in Christ Jesus our Lord.” Rom 8:38-39

21:43 - 23:25 “In your patience possess ye your souls.” Luke 21:19

23:35 – 24:41 “The light of the body is the eye: if therefore thine eye be single, thy whole body shall be full of light.” Matt 6:22

24:41 – 25:36 We are free to desire anything we want, but if we desire something not of God, the Devil will always take something from us.

[New Martyr Timothy of Esphigmenou – a “false” apostate.](#)

Audio: http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/saints-10-29_2022+timothy-of-esphigmenou.mp3

YouTube: <https://youtu.be/wC5hQ2b1zNg>

The life of my favorite New Martyr of the Turkish Yoke. Timothy became a “false” apostate – he feigned conversion to Islam in order to save his wife, and the story gets even more interesting from there. An excerpt, from a sermon entitled: [“The New Martyrs of the Turkish Yoke teach us how to use our freedom, against the day when we are not free”](#)

[A Christian reaction to the Supreme Court overturning of Row v Wade](#) Audio or Video

http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/misc_2022+christian-reaction-to-roe-v-wade-overturn.mp3

YouTube: <https://youtu.be/W4CsJBG9W4k>

On the day after the historic overturning of Roe V Wade by the Supreme Court, we talk about the sober reaction a Christian must have to this news. It is never right to do something that is wrong. Overturning an immoral law is necessary, but NOT SUFFICIENT. We should not “celebrate” – we must increase our prayer. There is still a terrible amount of suffering.

Apologies about the recording quality. I made a mistake in recording. If I have time, I will edit the transcript and record again. This is a critical topic, and I did not want to let perfection be the enemy of the good (enough).

[Confession talk at St Iakavos camp: what, why, how?](http://www.orthodox.net/catechism/catechism_2022-06-23+confession-talk-at-st-iakavos-camp.mp3)

http://www.orthodox.net/catechism/catechism_2022-06-23+confession-talk-at-st-iakavos-camp.mp3

Talk to youth at St Iakavos camp about confession, with Fr Seraphim and Sister Maxime. **WHAT** is it for, and what does the priest think of someone who confesses a terrible sin, and, **WHY** do we confess, **HOW** to prepare for it. And other stuff, such as what is the one thing in your life you cannot do without and why should we pray for anyone who harms us. IT is a lot, in about 25 minutes.

0:09 – 8:16 What is confession for?

8:25 – 11:29 Why pray for those who have harmed you, and how to pray for them.

11:29 – 13:42 What to confess? Not a list of “things”; it is not “formal”. And about modern forms of confession that are not beneficial.

13:42 – 18:27 How do you prepare for confession? Concentrate on who you are, and your relationships.

18:35 – 22:03 What is one thing in your life you cannot do without?

22:05 – 25:15 What does the priest think about someone if they confess a terrible sin? Will his opinion of the person be negative

23:45 - 24:48 Sins of the flesh